British paranoia. Looking back at this moment of triumph four years later, in 1841, he boasted in his memoirs that Persia had at this period become a ‘spectre’ which robbed the London Cabinet of sleep, knowing as they did the ease with which Russia could swoop down from Herat and ignite Hindustan. ‘In order to set India on fire, Russia had but to wish it,’ he wrote.[6]

MacNeill was left with no alternative but to sit in his Teheran study and scribble an alarmist polemic which he published anonymously as *The Progress and Present Position of Russia in the East*. ‘The only nation in Europe which attempts to aggrandize itself at the expense of its neighbours is Russia,’ he fumed. ‘Russia alone threatens to overturn thrones, subvert Empires, and subdue nations hitherto independent . . . The integrity and Independence of Persia is necessary to the security of India and of Europe; and any attempt to subvert the one is a blow struck at the other – an unequivocal act of hostility to England.’ This spirited diatribe ignored the obvious fact that the expansion of British possessions in India had continued without interruption throughout the first half of the nineteenth century, gobbling up far more land and overturning many more thrones than anything achieved by Russia; but the book was nevertheless well received and widely read in London, and added to the growing certainty in Westminster that a major clash with Russia was looming in Persia and Afghanistan.[7]

MacNeill was right however that, whatever the more cautious views of Tsar Nicholas and his ministers in St Petersburg, his rival Count Simonitch certainly did have strategic ambitions, at the heart of which lay his hopes of establishing a Russian base at Herat, a six-week march from the British frontier at Ludhiana. Recently, MacNeill’s spies at the Russian Legation in Teheran had passed on confusing intelligence – ‘absurd stories about a Muscovite prince’ who was said to be expected on the Iranian frontier at the head of a body of 10,000 men who would assist the Persians in their siege of Herat. The details of the intelligence sounded suspect; but they seemed to hint at the existence of some Russian move on Afghanistan via Persia. Rawlinson realised that the blond officer leading the Cossack party he had just cantered past ‘could be the man alluded to . . . My curiosity was of course excited. In such a state of affairs as preceded the siege of Herat, the mere fact of a Russian gentleman travelling in Khorasan was suspicious. In